NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 2♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥J

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ K 10 9 3
♥ A K Q 5
♦ A 8
♣ A 8 6

♠ Q 6 2
♥ 8 7 3
♦ K 9 7 4 3
♣ K J



♠ 8 5
♥ 10 4 2
♦ Q J 10 5
♣ Q 10 9 4

♠ A J 7 4
♥ J 9 6
♦ 6 2
♣ 7 5 3 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♥	Pass	3NT
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦Q

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with 4 cards in both Majors you respond 3♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

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Partner would not use Stayman unless he held a 4-card Major suit himself. Since he didn't like your ♥s it follows that he must have 4 ♠s.

So you correct the 3NT contract to 4♠.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♦Q.

If you had left it in 3NT you'd have 8 top tricks and a ♠ finesse for 9.

But you're in 4♠.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 4

If you can guess the ♠Q your problems are over. But just in case you dislike those 50% guesses, try to find a better Plan.

Another possibility is that a defender holds either a singleton or doubleton ♠Q so you can pick up the suit by leading ♠ A K. This is smaller than a 50% chance.

But there is more to the odds than that. Suppose you try the second possibility and play off both the ♠A and ♠K but the ♠Q does **NOT** drop. You are still not dead! You just leave the ♠Q out there and start on ♥s. As long as the defender who holds the ♠Q has at least 3 ♥s he will be unable to ruff until after you have discarded dummy's ♦ loser.

The extra chance makes this Plan your best hope.

You could have made the contract easily by playing West for the ♠Q.

You could have gone down easily by playing East for the ♠Q.

Or you could have made it whoever held the ♠Q by using the "improved" plan.

Board 2
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ J 3 ♦ A J 10 3 ♣ Q J 10 8	
♠ K 8 7 3 ♥ 5 ♦ K Q 9 4 2 ♣ 9 4 3	N W E S	♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A Q 8 7 4 2 ♦ 6 ♣ K 7 5
	♠ J 10 6 ♥ K 10 9 6 ♦ 8 7 5 ♣ A 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♥	Dbl
All Pass			

2♥ by East
Lead: ♠J

East is to play 2♥ Doubled.

This is the only Deal like this out of the 100.

No Declarer Plan for you to make, no tricks to look for.

Just play through the deal as you think it might go and see how many tricks you can set East. Enjoy.

Sometimes the opponents make overcalls which disrupt the smooth flow of your side's bidding. You and your partner need to have ways of dealing with these disruptions. One possibility is the **lebensohl** convention which is used a few times in these 100 Deals. There are lots of other methods out there, and you may not care for lebensohl. One of the big reasons we use it is that it includes a penalty double - some other methods use the double for other reasons.

So, in lebensohl an immediate double of their overcall of partner's 1NT opener is for penalties. Just like this one - punish them if they dare try to disrupt your bidding!

The contract is 2♥ doubled, played by East.

To see all the hands

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ A 6
♥ 9 7 2
♦ K 10 8 3
♣ A K Q 5

♠ 9 5 3
♥ J 10 8 6
♦ Q 9 7 2
♣ 9 4



♠ 10 7 4 2
♥ A 5 4 3
♦ J 4
♣ 10 8 2

♠ K Q J 8
♥ K Q
♦ A 6 5
♣ J 7 6 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	4NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by South
Lead: ♥J

Partner's 4NT bid is not Blackwood, it is the Quantitative 4NT. He is unsure whether to bid 6NT or not, so is inviting you to do so.

With 15 points you are supposed to pass. With 17 points you are supposed to bid 6NT. Wouldn't you know it, 16 points. Today you feel bold, so you say 6NT.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♥J.

East plays the ♥A and returns the ♥3.

Winner List: ♠ = 4 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 11

One trick is already lost and at first glance it looks like your only slim chance will be for the ♦ Q J to fall doubleton.

But a dummy has a very important card, the ♥9. You know from the opening lead that West holds the ♥10, so if he happens to hold the only guard in ♦s you will be able to squeeze him in the red suits.

You don't even have to do anything special. Play your 4 ♣ winners, then 3 ♠ winners.

Now play the ♠J and watch West's discard. If he throws the ♥10 dummy's ♥9 will become a winner. If he doesn't throw the ♥10 then you know dummy's ♥9 is worthless so discard it and hope the ♦s are good.

Squeeze plays can be complex to figure out and difficult to execute.

But not always. Sometimes they just happen, like this one. You were really hoping for the ♦Q and ♦J to fall and you fell into the squeeze instead.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 ♥ K 7 4 ♦ 9 8 4 2 ♣ 10 6 5 3 2	
♠ 8 5 2 ♥ Q 9 8 6 2 ♦ K Q 6 ♣ A 8		♠ Q 7 3 ♥ A 10 5 3 ♦ A J 7 ♣ K Q 9
	♠ A K J 9 6 4 ♥ J ♦ 10 5 3 ♣ J 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	2♠
3♥	Pass	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♠10

When partner opens 1NT, interference can easily gum up your smooth bidding sequences. Playing the lebensohl convention, your 3♥ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game.

It doesn't always work out so well, but here partner had an easy 4♥ bid.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♠10.

Whatever you play, South takes the ♠ A K J and then plays a small ♣. North started with just one ♠.

Loser List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

Don't let that Question Mark by the ♥ losers mislead you - if you are going to make this contract you cannot lose a ♥ trick at all! Is there any hope?

The odds aren't good, but you actually have **TWO** possibilities for success. If North holds the singleton ♥K, you can play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥A, dropping the ♥K, then finesse South out of his ♥J. Or, if South holds the singleton ♥J you can play your ♥Q, finessing North for the ♥K and at the same time smothering South's ♥J.

Which basket will you put your eggs into?

The answer is simple Bridge math! South started with 6 ♠s leaving him 7 cards outside the ♠ suit. North started with just 1 ♠, leaving him with 12 cards outside the ♠ suit. Obviously South is much more likely to have a singleton ♥ than North.

So you win the ♣A in your hand, play the ♥Q and let it ride if North does not cover.

Then you

Ahh, success.

But to tell the truth, the Bridge math wasn't really complete. Distribution-wise it was just fine, but there is also the question of strength.

The fact that South overcalled makes it more likely that he holds more high cards than North, and this skews the odds toward South holding the ♥K.

But think about it. If South does in fact hold the singleton ♥K, and if you cleverly drop it by playing dummy's ♥A it won't help you. You will then have to lose a trick to North's ♥J.